

She, too, has chosen a difficult career; she trained as an actress, moved to LA, and had—like her brother—approached her career in a disciplined, organized way.

But these are not careers in which discipline and organization come easily or pay off readily. There are no fixed hours. And no fixed route to professional advancement. Half the work you do, at least it seems to us, is just figuring out what work to do.

Our actress has had some success on TV and the movies. But she hasn't gotten the major roles she hopes for—yet.

“I've been in LA for two years already. I'm going to keep at it for another three years, according to my plan. But if it still isn't working, I'm going to have to find something else to do.”

It's a rough life. She lives in a tiny studio apartment and works from dawn to dusk trying to get acting jobs. She supports herself, barely, by doing modeling work on the side.

Her brother, meanwhile, is literally a starving artist, working one day a week as a handyman to help pay the bills.

We don't know how others do it, but our children couldn't afford to be starving artists without family support. Rents are too high. Health care . . . transportation—if they were forced to pay 100 percent of their living costs, they'd have to give up on their artistic careers and find other lines of work.

The point we are making is that success doesn't always come immediately. And it's not easy to sustain a career that doesn't provide quick, positive feedback. But in our experience, it pays to stay the course.

Starting out in life, young people are practically interchangeable parts. They leave school not knowing much of anything. If they can read and write clearly, they have an advantage over most college graduates. But school doesn't prepare them very well for real life. School problems are bounded, controlled, and simplified. Usually, they are idealized, with the confusing parts taken out. In history, for example, they are taught broad themes and specific “facts.” But the sequence of events in real life doesn't follow simple scripts. Instead, it is endlessly complex with “facts” that are always subject to doubt.

Historical characters are like cartoon figures, made into heroes or villains according to the storyline. In real life, they are like the people we know